the chaplain. I tried to offer advice, suck it up, it might be better once you're used to it. But then he put his bulk in front of me and, in an endearingly childlike way, told me point-blank that he was going AWOL—a crime in the military—and asked me whether I would tell anybody. It was only then that I noticed he'd brought his laundry bag. He meant that he was going AWOL that very moment.

I wasn't sure how to deal with the situation, beyond trying to talk some sense into him. I warned him that going AWOL was a bad idea, that he'd end up with a warrant out for his arrest and any cop in the country could pick him up for the rest of his life. But the guy only shook his head. Where he lived, he said, deep in the mountains, they didn't even have cops. This, he said, was his last chance to be free.

I understood, then, that his mind was made up. He was much more mobile than I was, and he was big. If he ran, I couldn't chase him; if I tried to stop him, he might snap me in half. All I could do was report him, but if I did, I'd be penalized for having let the conversation get this far without calling for reinforcements and beating him with a crutch.

I was angry. I realized I was yelling at him. Why didn't he wait until I was in the latrine to make a break for it? Why was he putting me in this position?

He spoke softly. "You're the only one who listens," he said, and began to cry.

The saddest part of that night is that I believed him. In the company of a quarter thousand, he was alone. We stood in silence as the fireworks popped and snapped in the distance. I sighed and said, "I've got to go to the latrine. I'm going to be a while." Then I limped away and didn't look back.

That was the last I ever saw of him. I think I realized, then and there, that I wasn't long for the army, either.

My next doctor's appointment was merely confirmation.

The doctor was a tall, lanky Southerner with a wry demeanor. After examining me and a new set of X-rays, he said that I was in no condition to continue with my company. The next phase of training was airborne, and he told me, "Son, if you jump on those legs, they're going to turn into powder."

I was despondent. If I didn't finish the basic training cycle on time, I'd lose my slot in 18X, which meant that I'd be reassigned according to the needs of the army. They could make me into whatever they wanted: regular infantry, a mechanic, a desk jockey, a potato peeler, or—in my greatest nightmare—doing IT at the army's help desk.

The doctor must have seen how dejected I was, because he cleared his throat and gave me a choice: I could get recycled and try my luck with reassignment, or